

Action Plan for Reforming Research Assessment at Østfold University College

Østfold University College (ØUC) signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment on 11 November 2022. This document is intended as an action plan that specifies how ØUC will meet the agreement's core commitments within its stipulated timeframe. This action plan is shared with the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) community by the end of 2023 in order to render our efforts transparent, enable constructive feedback, and be a source of inspiration to those who might need it.

ØUC's Interpretation of the Agreement's Goals

A superior goal of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment is that assessment of research, researchers, and research organizations acknowledges and values the range of outputs that these people, processes, and institutions realize in the name of impactful quality research. The agreement is clear that this requires assessment through primarily qualitative judgements supplemented by responsible use of quantitative indicators. In Norway in general, there is hardly any tradition for relying primarily on quantitative indicators when it comes to the assessment of research. There are nevertheless good reasons to improve processes and procedures related to research assessment. Universities Norway (UHR) has in this regard developed the Norwegian Career Assessment Matrix (NOR-CAM), which builds upon the European Open Science Career Assessment Matrix (OS-CAM). In order to ensure alignment with similar reform processes across Europe, ØUC has decided that our institutional reformation of research assessment will happen through an implementation of NOR-CAM that is adapted to ØUC's unique study program and research portfolio.

Resource Allocation and Working Group Mandate

Joining the CoARA community obliges ØUC to map, develop, and possibly establish new tools for how researcher qualifications are assessed with regards to employment and promotion, and these must be in line with the agreement's core commitments. ØUC has decided to appoint a working group that will operationalize the agreement's intentions by developing a separate competence assessment matrix that is adapted to ØUC's needs. The working group will consist of representatives from HR, the research administration and academic staff from various disciplines who have different experiences from employment and promotion processes. The reformation work must include the job categories lecturer, senior lecturer, docent, associate professor, and professor.

The working group shall:

1. Map existing processes, including tools, routines, guidelines, and resources, regarding employment and promotion.
2. Establish a competence assessment matrix that is based on the NOR-CAM toolbox and is adapted to ØUC's needs.
3. Recommend development of existing processes, and possibly the establishment of new ones, in line with the competence assessment matrix.
4. Deliver a report to the project board that explains the points mentioned, and that contains an implementation plan that fulfills ØUC's obligations according to the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment. The implementation plan should point out how the recommendations can affect the use of resources in employment and promotion processes.

The work must be seen in the context of relevant national regulations and form the basis for ØUC's further work with career development and guidance.

Composition of the Working Group

The working group consists of the following members:

- Kristian Sandbekk Norsted (Project Manager, Senior Advisor, the Library)
- Elisabeth Kihl-Stenrød (Head of Section, Human Resources)
- Roswitha King (Professor, Department of Economics, Innovation and Society)
- Øystein Haugen (Professor, Department of Computer Science and Communication)
- Arnstein Hjelde (Professor, Department of Languages, Literature and Culture)
- Erik Thorstensen (Associate Professor, Department of Natural Sciences, Practical-Aesthetic, Social and Religious Studies)
- Karen Erika Earle Kipphoff (Professor, Norwegian Theatre Academy)
- Hadi Strømme Lile (Professor, Department of Welfare, Management and Organisation)
- Kristin Myhre (Senior Lecturer, Department of Nursing, Health and Laboratory science)

Timeline

ØUC's effort to reform research assessment on an institutional level shall happen within the following timeframe:

- **January to June 2024:** The working group will meet on four occasions (action plan for this particular project is specified in a separate document) in order to work to fulfill the mandate specified above
- **17 June 2024:** Deadline for project report, including plan for implementation
- **August 2024 to February 2025:** Implementation phase in which ØUC's resources related to employment and promotion will be updated, developed and put to use (a new working group will take care of implementation)
- **March 2025 to August 2026:** The reformed resources for research evaluation will be in operation
- **August to December 2026:** Evaluation of the implemented reform (a new working group will take care of this evaluation)